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***Yellowface*: The Rat Race That Is The Publishing World**

Yellowface, the satirical 2023 novel by R.F. Kuang, condemns the racial politics that can fuel the cutthroat nature of literary publication. The two main authors featured in *Yellowface* are June Hayward, a struggling white writer, and her friend Athena Liu, a successful novelist whose works revolve around the struggles of Asian communities. The novel's focus on racial politics in publishing comes into play when Athena suddenly dies. Subsequently, June finds herself taking on Athena's unfinished manuscript, and with it, a new "racially ambiguous" identity that makes her more marketable to readers who seem to take overtly conscious pity on all Asian diasporas regardless of their actual circumstances. **By discussing June's adoption of the manuscript and her new literary identity, Athena's high privilege that disconnected her from the issues she wrote about, and the literary agents' eagerness to publish works that cast pity upon marginalized communities, *Yellowface* pulls no punches in highlighting the dangers of literary opportunism.**

A majority of the novel focuses on June's opportunism: she is so determined to succeed as a writer that she unabashedly steals Athena's unfinished manuscript, adopts the pen name and persona of Juniper Song, and publishes the book under her new identity. What June initially describes as a service to her late friend is clearly a self-centered and overly expedient attempt at success, which becomes evident to the reader as her literary agents inform her that the book's ethnically conscious themes will make it very successful: "The whole time I'm thinking, *I've made it. I've fucking made it.* I'm living Athena's life. [...] I have everything I ever wanted - and

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it tastes just as delicious as I always imagined” (Kuang 35). June’s willingness to profit from Athena’s work is defined by a sense of bitterness towards the publishing industry for disregarding her previous works. June knows that stealing the manuscript is wrong; however, as she takes it on and makes it her own, she justifies her actions to herself, stating that nobody need know that the writing belonged to Athena, even suggesting that Athena might have approved of her decision to take on her work: “And maybe Athena would have even wanted this. She was always into trippy literary hoaxes like this. [...] ‘People come to a text with so many prejudices formed by what they think they know about the author,’ she’s said before” (Kuang 37). By stating that she would have wanted the situation to turn out the way it did, June twists Athena’s words in order to exonerate herself of wrongdoing, so that she can steal Athena’s work with a clear conscience. June’s exploitation of Athena’s beliefs for her own self-vindication are testament to her ruthless determination to succeed; her denial of the very idea that she is plagiarizing and exploiting her friend’s work demonstrates how much she is willing to pander to her readers in order to reach Athena’s level of success in the literary world. Through the demonstration of June’s opportunistic and dishonest actions, *Yellowface* symbolizes her as a slave to the rat race that is the publishing world, and soundly criticizes her not only for plagiarizing Athena’s work, but also for subscribing to the publishing industry’s reliance on racial exploitation in order to gain readership.

While June’s opportunistic theft of Athena’s manuscript and her willingness to cover up the theft makes her an unreliable narrator, she also validly criticizes Athena for profiting from the suffering of others to achieve literary success. Once, June recalls an outing where she and Athena visited a Korean War memorial, which Athena used to conduct research for one of her

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books. Athena delves into every element that she could use for her work, even interrogating a disabled, visiting veteran. June calls out Athena's "magpie's eye for suffering," recalling how Athena described her work as raising awareness of past atrocities, but asserting that, due to her sheltered life spent in luxury, she had no right to discuss them: "Athena never personally experienced suffering. She just got rich from it. She wrote an award-winning short story based on what she saw [...] And she wasn't even Korean" (Kuang 109-111). June's criticism of Athena's writing practices is valid to an extent: finding stories about global acts of cruelty to write about can be ethically questionable when one profits from readers' willingness to read about those stories, especially if a writer does not have a thorough understanding of the communities they are writing about. That is a criticism that Kuang makes of readership and publishing as a whole. In an interview with NPR conducted in 2023, Kuang argues, "You would see Asian American writers being told that you can't write anything except about [...] the difficulties of being Asian American in the U.S. And I think that's anathema to what fiction should be. I think fiction should be about [...] stepping into other people's shoes and empathizing with the other" (Kelly). Although Kuang criticizes that aspect of publishing, she also maintains that Athena is far from blameless due to her tendency to "steal" stories and her insistence on "being the only Asian American in the room" (Kelly); much like June, she has become a slave in the game of publishing in the sense that she uses her "Asian" identity as a licence to prey on events that might have caused trauma for some people. Regardless of how much privilege she has grown up in, and regardless of how much that privilege has enabled her to become successful, Athena has simply exploited her race through her writing in order to achieve commercial success. Athena's subscription to the publishing world's exploitative nature, to the extent that it disconnects her

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from the reality of the social issues she writes about and causes her to view them as literary fodder, is another publishing pitfall that *Yellowface* draws attention to and criticizes.

While Athena's exploitative writing practices are criticized in detail, the novel's cautionary message against literary opportunism is made most visible through the disapproving analysis of the publishing officers', literary agents' and other authors' behavior, especially those who work at and are affiliated with Eden Publishing House. What is especially striking is the agents' mistreatment of editorial assistant Candice Lee. Candice's unfair treatment is foreshadowed by June's dislike of her, which is made clear when Candice asks for a "sensitivity reader" to review the manuscript. Another agent, Brett, suggests that Candice herself serve as the sensitivity reader, despite Candice being "Korean American, not Chinese American, and that Brett's assumption is a racist microaggression" (Kuang 65). Here, Kuang not only criticizes a lazy practice in publishing, but also the dismissal of all Asian Americans as one singular race, without considering the sensitivities and experiences of individual diasporas. What is seen here is the application of a "single story," the concept explored by Nigerian writer Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, which "...show[s] a people as one thing, as only one thing, over and over again, and that is what they become" (Adichie). In the case of *Yellowface*, the diaspora of Asian American people - a very diverse diaspora at that - is being shown by Eden's publishers through the singular frame that makes all of them, regardless of whether they are of Korean, Japanese, Filipino, Indian or Sri Lankan descent, seem deserving of nothing but pity. Nobody, neither publishers nor readers, views the crisis of the Chinese Labor Corps during World War I as anything but fodder for excessive pity. They have subscribed to the "single story" that all Asian Americans were affected by this particular issue, when it was actually an issue very specific and

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sensitive to the Chinese and Chinese American communities; they desperately want to market it to the many readers who have also subscribed to that “single story” to the extent that they submit to June’s decision to forgo the sensitivity reading. In addition, Kuang also criticizes the way other writers for Eden, in particular Marnie Kimball and Jen Walker, defend June at the expense of other writers who bring forth not-unfounded allegations of plagiarism against June. When one writer, Diana Qiu, suggests that June might have stolen Athena’s work, Jen and Marnie respond to the accusations by making personal attacks against Diana, insulting her intelligence, her sanity, and even her physical appearance (Kuang 161). Being a satirical novel, *Yellowface* exaggerates these actions in order to criticize any real-life instances of competitive bullying; by doing so, it highlights the competitive nature of one publishing industry, and cautions the real-time publishing industry against falling into the trap of milking real racial issues for commercial benefit.

In conclusion, *Yellowface* by R.F. Kuang is a critique and cautionary tale towards the modern-day publishing industry, highlighting the dangers of opportunism in publishing, and demonstrating the dangers of exploiting past societal issues that people have suffered because of. In particular, it criticizes June’s plagiarism of Athena’s manuscript for her own commercial gain, Athena’s exploitation of her Chinese ethnicity and various race-based atrocities to maintain her oversimplified, token status as an Asian-American writer, and Eden Publishing House as a whole for buying into the concept of writing pity stories about marginalized communities, and using those writing practices as unfair ammunition against other writers who raise the question of whether June committed plagiarism or not.

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